

Last commissioner standing

送信者: POLITICO Brussels Playbook 受信日時: 2026-07-24 13:54

【メール原文】

Presented by Google By GABRIEL GAVIN GOOD MORNING — I'm Gabriel Gavin. And whether you're sipping a piña colada in Pamplona or lingering over work on

Presented by Google

By GABRIEL GAVIN

PRESENTED BY

Send tips here | Follow us @gerardofortuna @NicholasVinocur @GabrielGavin | Listen to Playbook and view in your browser

GOOD MORNING — I'm Gabriel Gavin. And whether you're sipping a piña colada in Pamplona or lingering over work on Rue de la Loi ... welcome to the Brussels bubble holiday season. But wait — if you're winding down, who's running the joint? More on that below.

START HERE: The Trump administration has finalized new double-digit tariffs on dozens of trading partners, with the EU, Canada, the U.K. and Mexico facing a 10 percent duty. But so far, there's been no direct retaliation for the EU's €890 million fine against Google — despite the harsh words about the Digital Markets Act from Under Secretary of State Jacob Helberg.

In today's Playbook:

- No way: a proposal linking the EU's seven-year budget to reforms sparks a backlash.
- What war? Don't give up on Europe's frontline countries as holiday destinations.
- Faces in the crowd: Nina Warken, Kathleen Van Brempt, Marie Curie, Franziska Hoppermann, Kent Walker, Christina Rafti, Lelde Līce-Līcīte, Jamieson Greer, Emmanuel de Saxe, Svenja Hahn and many more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Week Ender Podcast: Anne talks to former French Defense Minister Sylvie Goulard and Simon Fraser, a former head of the British Foreign Office, about what Andy Burnham means for Europe.

****A message from Google: YouTube & Google play an important role in young people's lives, which is why we've put their safety, privacy and wellbeing at the forefront of our work for over a decade. That includes responsible features, parental controls, default protections and age-appropriate content – as well as ideas and tips for families.****

DRIVING THE DAY

WHO'S IN CHARGE? Top EU officials, diplomats and politicians are setting off on their summer holidays today, after holding their final College and EU ambassadors' meetings. Left in their wake is an unlucky pool of commissioners, who will take turns running the executive while everyone else hits the beach.

End of term: Innovation chief Ekaterina Zaharieva is first up, according to a planning note seen by Playbook: She will take the reins at the end of this week as the Berlaymont's solo boss, in case of a crisis. A few hardworking colleagues will still be wrapping up official business abroad, however, including top diplomat Kaja Kallas in Manila and Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius in Washington.

Cycling through: From Aug. 8 to Aug. 14, when Brussels is expected to grind to a halt, Budget Commissioner Piotr Serafin will step in. He'll be followed by energy czar Dan Jørgensen, who had previously told Playbook he would like to "be in the Berlaymont watching the Tour de France on my laptop" while holding down the fort (it may be a bit late for that). For the final week of August, rule-of-law chief Michael McGrath will be in the hot seat. Let's hope the air-conditioning is up and running again.

Comings and goings: When the commissioners finally return from their break, Brussels will look a little different: a string of departures and appointments will start taking effect before the rentrée.

Diplo-shuffle: Ambassadors on Thursday held a farewell dinner for Cyprus' Permanent Representative Christina Rafti, who will hand over to her deputy Giorgios Ioannides. It marks the end of a presidency that delivered on major achievements like the first round of seven-year budget negotiations and the 20th Russia sanctions package. The evening was also a chance to say goodbye to Latvia's top envoy, Lelde Līce-Līcīte, who is succeeded by her deputy Reinis Brusbārdis after five years of leading intense diplomacy on sanctions, hybrid threats and support for Ukraine.

Moving on: Some of the bubble's best-known diplomatic spokespeople are also transitioning to proverbial greener pastures. The Netherlands' Melle van Dijk is joining Prime Minister Rob Jetten's office to work on "reducing strategic dependencies," as Rutger Fransen arrives from The Hague to take his old job. Estonia's Triin Oppi heads back to Tallinn to lead EU communications. Belgium's Alexandre Brex is handing over to Stanley Matthys, who is currently posted in Kinshasa.

Foreign affairs: U.K. Ambassador to the EU Lindsay Croisdale-Appleby departs after six years in the post. The former British ambassador to China, Caroline Wilson, will take his place. "I am grateful for the warmth and openness of so many Brussels counterparts as we worked together to strengthen the U.K.-EU relationship," Croisdale-Appleby told Playbook.

More moves: On the other side of the Channel, Finnish diplomat Jukka Salovaara takes up his post as the EU's top envoy in London. Commission Foreign Affairs spokesperson Anitta Hipper moves to a policy role. And the EU foreign service's top official Belén Martínez Carbonell sets sail for Mexico as the race for her replacement gets underway .

Relax while you can, because the rentrée to-do list is already loaded: the EU's €2 trillion budget; the question of how to admit new members to the bloc; and the State of the European Union in mid-September. Brussels' new cast of diplomats, officials and spokespeople have their work cut out for them.

BIG AND BREAKING

CABINET CHANGES: Friedrich Merz's cabinet reshuffle appears to be underway, with media reports suggesting Health Minister Nina Warken will become the chancellor's new chief of staff — the first woman to take on the role in postwar Germany. CDU General Secretary Carsten Linnemann is set to fill the void as health minister.

TIME TO BRING AfD IN FROM THE COLD? The suggestion that Merz's centrist conservatives should break a long-held taboo and cooperate with the far-right Alternative for Germany has sparked a major political debate .

ON THE MONEY: The European Central Bank has unveiled its finalists for the redesign of the Euro banknotes , featuring birds, flowers and the portraits of figures like Marie Skłodowska Curie. A public survey has been launched inviting citizens to vote for their favorites, ahead of a decision expected at the end of the year.

ECOLOGICAL TURMOIL: The near-resignation of French Minister for Ecological Transition Monique Barbut points to the deepening fractures inside Emmanuel Macron's already embattled coalition.

HANDS ARE TIED: There may be a reason for the electoral appeal of Marine Le Pen and France's far right: many voters see no alternative. That's the conclusion of a new focus-group study .

TRUMP HOLDS FIRE — FOR NOW

BRACING FOR THE TRUTH BOMB: When this newsletter went to pixel, Donald Trump still hadn't expressed an opinion about Brussels' €890 million penalty against Google. But the U.S. president's top trade official warned the fine could jeopardize the fragile transatlantic trade truce , Zoya Sheftalovich reports.

Bricks in the wall: U.S. Trade Representative Jamieson Greer said the fine created "massive uncertainty" around the Turnberry agreement, as Washington moved late on Thursday to rebuild a tariff wall after the U.S. Supreme Court struck down his earlier duties. Trump's temporary 10 percent global levy was renewed late on Thursday for 17 trading partners, while 43 other countries, including Japan, China, South Korea and Australia, will face a 12.5 percent tariff rate.

Fire and fury: Greer accused Brussels of taking an "increasingly aggressive approach targeting U.S. technology firms" and said the bloc was committing "intellectual-property theft." U.S. Ambassador to the EU Andrew Puzder said the EU was "using regulation as a blunt instrument against American innovation ." Greer, Puzder and Helberg all mentioned POLITICO's reporting last week that a €4.6 billion sanction issued to Google in 2018 would be put toward the EU's 2026 budget — amounting to more than 2 percent of the total pot.

Not anti-U.S.; just pro-EU: The European Commission earlier on Wednesday insisted that it was not singling out American tech. "Our digital legislation is not up for negotiation," spokesperson Thomas Regnier said, arguing that the rules were "objective" and "non-discriminatory."

Rules are rules: Brussels must keep explaining to Washington that the Google case followed EU law and a lengthy process, said Kathleen Van Brempt, a Belgian MEP from the Socialists & Democrats group who sits on the European Parliament's International Trade Committee. "You can agree or disagree, you say whatever you want, but this is our legislation," she told our colleague Camille Gijss last night, fresh from

a meeting with U.S. officials in Washington.

Google hits back: "This isn't fair competition; it's product degradation driven by a small group of self-serving complainants," said Kent Walker, president of global affairs at Google and Alphabet.

Bigger fight: The EU is also awaiting the outcome of a U.S. forced-labor investigation that could support fresh tariffs, with further probes into excess capacity, pharmaceutical pricing and digital policies in the pipeline. Trump may be quiet for now, but the Google fine has landed squarely in the next transatlantic trade battle.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen was among those given a gun as a gift by Turkey's President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan at the end of the NATO summit in Ankara. Her firearm is going to a museum. But what normally happens to gifts presented to members of the Commission? There's an underground room in the bowels of the Berlaymont, the Commission's HQ, known to insiders as the "Ali Baba cave." Ethics guidelines forbid commissioners from accepting many of the gifts they are offered, but they often have to make a show of publicly accepting them to avoid a diplomatic slight. Assistants later squirrel the gifts away in the "cave."

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

BORDER WATCH

SAVE OUR SUMMER SPOTS: The military threat posed by Russia is keeping tourists away from some of the EU's most beautiful border regions, seven of the bloc's frontier states are warning. In a letter sent to the European Commission Thursday and seen by Playbook, ministers from Latvia, Bulgaria, Estonia, Lithuania, Poland, Romania and Slovakia warn more needs to be done to protect their economies.

Warning: "Geopolitical developments and security concerns have had a significant impact on tourism in the eastern border regions of our countries. Tourism flows have declined considerably in most of these regions," the letter says .

Is Northern Europe the new Southern Europe? In better news for border countries, while the Mediterranean region swelters in successive heat waves, travelers are increasingly being drawn to the balmy lakes and expansive woodlands of the Baltic-Nordic region. A report from the European Travel Commission this month found heat waves are a growing concern, alongside security.

Baltic surprises: Anecdotally, Playbook has heard Sopot and Klaipeda mentioned as holiday destinations this year as often as Seville or Kos ...

3 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

HOT AIR: The EU's proposed watering down of its flagship carbon emissions policy faces its first test today. Environment ministers meet in Dublin with the dividing lines drawn for a debate that will define the rest of the year.

EYE ON THE INTERNET: EU countries on Thursday reinstated a law allowing tech companies to scan private communications for child abuse material. But the controversial issue faces scrutiny from lawmakers and capitals at its next trilogue in September.

ECB READY TO RAISE RATES: European Central Bank officials are prepared to raise borrowing costs in September unless there's a clear improvement in the eurozone inflation outlook, Bloomberg reports quoting "people familiar with the situation."

BUDGET HEAVYWEIGHTS PUSH BACK

CLASH OVER CASH-FOR-REFORMS MODEL: A group of 10 countries including France, Spain and Italy came out against the Commission's plan to link payments to reforms in its new seven-year budget, four EU diplomats told Gregorio Sorigi.

Who's against: The EU executive had proposed linking regular payouts to the fulfillment of reforms from 2028. The bloc of 10 countries — which also includes net recipients such as Hungary, Malta and Poland — opposed this approach during a meeting of EU ambassadors on Wednesday. The Netherlands defended the new blueprint. Critics say that the model could cause regions to lose money when governments fail to carry out the required reforms.

The modernizers ... and the rest: Other fiscally conservative EU members, such as Sweden and Denmark, have long argued that conditionality could help poorer EU countries become economically more efficient. But two EU diplomats from the anti-cash-for-reforms camp, granted anonymity like others to discuss the sensitive talks, said the frugals' real motivation is to slow down payments to less affluent regions.

Council grumblings: As budget negotiations enter crunch time, resistance to the Commission's blueprint is brewing. "There seems to be a wake-up call," said one of the diplomats. A second said: "We don't want recommendations to become impositions."

What's certain: Some EU leaders will try diluting the cash-for-reforms model in upcoming summits after the summer break. Luxembourg, which voted against the new budget blueprint last month over opposition to reform conditionality, has made this a red line in the negotiations.

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: High of 24C, mainly sunny.

CELEBRATE SUMMER IN GHENT: There are just three days left to get yourself to Ghent's iconic annual festival Gentse Feesten, which closes this Sunday, Hanne Cokelaere reports. The festival, which takes over the medieval city's center for 10 days each year, is an attack on the senses — in the best possible way. There's music, theater, street art, dance classes and food trucks on every street corner ... and a program that runs through the night.

Word of advice to visitors aiming to catch the last train: It leaves before midnight. What's more, Ghent's station is a trek from the city center, and you'll find that moving around at the height of Gentse Feesten takes a lot longer than usual. Although, you wouldn't be the first day-trippers to get stuck in the city until morning.

IF GHENT'S NOT YOUR JAM: Boechout, a stone's throw from Antwerp, hosts its Sfinks festival this weekend. The event is free and offers a podium to music from different corners of the world.

OR FOR THE WEEKDAY REVELERS ... Every Friday in July, a series of concerts takes over the squares of the city of Leuven. Beleuvenissen, a play on words on the Dutch word for experiences, belevenissen, has nine acts lined up for today.

ROYAL SAX APPEAL: Did you know that the youngest son of Belgium's King Philippe is also known as a DJ? Prince Emmanuel is one of the men behind the electronic dance group Vyntrix, which announced a new single called "Wonder" on Thursday. The prince of Saxe-Coburg-Gotha also plays the saxophone under the alias Emmanuel de Saxe — pun, we presume, very much intended.

BRUSSELS CLINCHES FIREFIGHTER DEAL: The Brussels government said on Thursday it had approved proposals to bolster resources for the city's fire brigade in a bid to end a strike that started Tuesday, Belgium's national day. Firefighters are striking to protest a staffing shortage. On Wednesday, the fire brigade called on Brussels residents to be extra cautious as the strike undercuts emergency services' capacity to respond.

SPOTTED ... sipping wine and rhubarb drink and tucking into an epic spread of smoked salmon and white fish, caesar salad and hunks of cheese at a farewell do for Estonian spokesperson Triin Oppi: Estonian Ambassador Kyllike Sillaste-Elling and deputy perm rep Katrin Juhandi; Helsingin Sanomat's Jarno Hartikainen; FT's Henry Foy and Laura Dubois; Contexte's Clothilde Goujard; Luxemburger Wort's Diego Velazquez; the Guardian's Jennifer Rankin; New York Times' Jeanna Smialek; Euractiv's Eddy Wax; WSJ's Dan Michaels; and POLITICO's Koen Verhelst and Zoya Sheftalovich.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: The government reshuffle rumor mill is in overdrive. For example: Franziska Hoppermann is said to be a shoo-in for the role of CDU general secretary.

London: PM Andy Burnham opens "No. 10 North" today, giving Westminster a chance to learn what the "not a gimmick" project looks like in practice.

Paris: Gabriel Attal won't be taking a vacation this summer — the Renaissance secretary general is in "permanent campaign mode."

Washington PM: Congress and oil markets have inflicted fresh setbacks on the Trump administration's war in Iran — just as the president threatens a dramatic escalation.

AGENDA

— High Representative Kaja Kallas attends the Kyiv–Manila Dialogue in Manila and meets the foreign ministers of Brazil, Cambodia, the Philippines and Sri Lanka.

— Defense Commissioner Andrius Kubilius meets defense experts and attends a roundtable with space companies in Washington, D.C.

— Informal meeting of environment ministers in Dublin.

BIRTHDAYS

Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič; former European Commissioners Marianne Thyssen and Jonathan Hill; MEPs Tomáš Kubín, Christine Singer and Angéline Furet; former MEPs Viktor Uspaskich, Burkhard Balz, Teresa Jiménez-Becerril, Margot Parker and Flavio Zanonato; Dalia Lahdo, from the Swedish Ministry of Foreign Affairs; EISMEA's Jakub Cebula; DPA's Juergen Baetz; POLITICO's Ghiță Kraszuk; Uzbek President Shavkat Mirziyoyev; Joan Enric Vives Sicília, former co-prince of Andorra; European Disability Forum's Daniel Casas Ballester.

Celebrating Saturday: MEPs Svenja Hahn and Grégory Allione; former MEP Gheorghe-Vlad Nistor; Danish Permanent Representation's Maj Emmertsen; Latvian politician Raimonds Bergmanis; former World Bank President Robert Zoellick; The Atlantic's Anne Applebaum.

Celebrating Sunday: MEP Lídia Pereira; former MEPs Nikki Sinclair, Vasile Blaga, José Manuel Fernandes and Martina Dlabajová; former New Zealand Prime Minister Jacinda Ardern; French writer Jean-Claude Grumberg; Nicholas Barnabò of Weil, Gotshal & Manges; Karel Janeček, creator of Democracy 21 and POLITICO 28 alum; former Australian PM John Howard; former British PM Liz Truss; ORF's Benedict Feichtner.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editor James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from Google:** We want to see a higher industry standard for safer features, content and settings. That's why we've spent a decade building tailored products and protections for our youngest viewers. YouTube Kids and Teen Accounts come with additional protections and controls, are easy to set up, and developed in partnership with independent experts. And our new industry-leading Shorts timer - which can be set to zero - joins Bedtime and Take a Break reminders and content settings in our parental controls. All part of our mission to protect kids in the digital world, not from it.**

SUBSCRIBE to the POLITICO newsletter family: Brussels Playbook | London Playbook | London Playbook PM | Playbook Paris | Berlin Playbook | Sunday Crunch | EU Influence | London Influence | D.C. Playbook | D.C. Influence | Canada Playbook | POLITICO Forecast | All our POLITICO Pro policy morning newsletters

This email was sent to shondo@iies.co.jp

[Update your preferences](#) | [Unsubscribe from this email](#) | [Unsubscribe from all emails](#)

POLITICO SRL · Rue de la Loi 62 · Brussels 1040 · Belgium